
April Alumni Update

1 message

The Eagle's Alumni Board <eagleadvisoryboard-gmail.com@shared1.ccsend.com>

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April 2026 - Alumni Newsletter

Gabrielle McNamee named editor-in-chief

The Eagle's advisory board has selected Local News Editor **Gabrielle McNamee** to be editor-in-chief for the 2026-27 academic year.

McNamee leads the News section's local team. Under her direction, the paper has covered the National Guard's deployment into the District, community response to the second Trump administration and protests of Immigration and Customs Enforcement action.

McNamee has been a member of staff since her freshman year. Congratulations, Gabrielle!



Thanks to our donors, Eagle leaders will receive larger stipends next school year. This will make leadership positions more accessible to students with financial need.

A History of The Eagle's Digital Transformation

By Hans Cathcart

My Eagle Achievement Awards tell you everything you need to know about my time at the paper: "For rollerblading his way into The Eagle's single largest computer purchase" and "Here's a new e-mail system, ethernet, production server, negative scanner and electronic newspaper! Now go away."

When The Eagle celebrated its 100th anniversary, it got me thinking about my time as the paper's first "Webmaster," and it's remarkable what we accomplished 30 years ago — connecting the office to the Internet, digitizing the photography workflow, and building The Eagle's first website.

But as with any great transformation, the foundations were already laid. The writers, photographers, editors and production staff were already producing award-winning content worth reading — without that, none of this would have mattered. And the often-overlooked business office was generating hundreds of thousands of dollars through advertising, funding the technology purchases that made it all possible.

What we built was extraordinary for the time: an automated system that generated interlinked HTML pages with author profiles, topic cross-references and a structure that anticipated modern content management systems — all in early 1996.

I've written a full oral history of this unheralded chapter in The Eagle's story. It's a tale of scrappy innovation, immaturity, and a cramped college newspaper office that served as a playground that launched alumni careers in journalism, technology, public relations, financial services, law and far beyond. [Click here to read it.](#)

Alumni and Staff News

Congratulations to **Anne Godlasky**, the new Director of Journalist Programmes at the Reuters Institute. "Anne will play a key role in pursuing our mission of exploring the future of journalism worldwide," according to a Reuters Institute [statement](#).

Olivia Alafriz started a new job covering the federal judiciary for Bloomberg Law.

The Eagle's Managing Editor for News **Payton Anderson** is the first recipient of the Amy Eisman Scholarship for Innovation in Journalism. The scholarship "honors the beloved AU professor's transformative impact on generations of journalists," according to the School of Communication's website. Eisman presented the award to Anderson in mid-April.

Abigail Hatting will start as a News Associate at CNN after she graduates from AU next month.

Jane Hall, an AU journalism professor and Eagle supporter, will retire in May. Hall is known for leading American Forum, a speaker series that connects AU students to prominent figures in politics and media. Hall has twice been chosen Professor of the Year by student government. Former students can reach her at jhall@american.edu.



Hall moderates a discussion with Seung Min Kim, David Winston and Celinda Lake in 2018. Photo by Maria Carrasco.

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